



HEALTH POLICY CAREERS EXPLAINED

**From Legislative Advocacy to Think Tanks to Health
System Consulting**

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Health policy is the intersection of healthcare, economics, law, and government. If you're fascinated by why healthcare works the way it does and how to change it, this might be your career path. The best part? You don't need to be a doctor. Health policy careers are diverse and impactful.

COMMON ROLES IN HEALTH POLICY

1. Health Policy Analyst / Research Associate

What they do: Research and analyze healthcare policies, legislation, and regulations. Write reports and policy briefs.

Where they work: Think tanks (e.g., RAND Corporation, Brookings), research institutes, consulting firms.

Background: Typically have an MPH, MPP (Master of Public Policy), or a PhD. Strong quantitative and writing skills.

2. Legislative Health Policy Advisor

What they do: Advise elected officials (members of Congress, state legislators, city council) on health-related bills. Draft legislation, prepare testimony, and analyze impacts of proposed laws.

Where they work: Congressional offices, state legislatures, government agencies.

Background: Often have a law degree (JD) or an MPP/MPH. Experience in policy advocacy is key.

3. Health Policy Advocate / Lobbyist

What they do: Advocate for specific health policies on behalf of organizations (e.g., American Heart Association, hospitals, pharmaceutical companies). Meet with legislators, organize campaigns, and mobilize supporters.

Where they work: Nonprofits, professional associations, hospitals, advocacy coalitions.

Background: Strong communication and relationship-building skills. Often have a master's degree.

4. Health Systems Consultant

What they do: Advise hospitals, health systems, or government agencies on improving efficiency, quality, or financial performance.

Where they work: Consulting firms (e.g., Deloitte, McKinsey, Chartis), independent practice.

Background: MBA, MHA (Master of Health Administration), or MPH. Data analysis and strategic thinking are crucial.

5. Government Agency Program Administrator

What they do: Oversee federal, state, or local health programs (e.g., Medicare, Medicaid, public health departments). Manage budgets, staff, and program implementation.

Where they work: CMS (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), state health departments, local public health offices.

Background: Often have an MPA, MHA, or MPH. Leadership experience is required.

6. Health Policy Communications Specialist

What they do: Translate complex policy information into accessible content for the public, journalists, or stakeholders.

Where they work: Nonprofits, government agencies, advocacy groups.

Background: Strong writing and journalism skills. Often have experience in communications or public relations.

HOW TO BREAK INTO HEALTH POLICY

- Build a strong academic foundation: Public health, economics, political science, or public policy are excellent majors.
- Internships: These are the single best way to get your foot in the door. Even unpaid internships can lead to full-time roles.
- Network: Attend health policy conferences (e.g., AcademyHealth annual meeting), join policy interest groups at your university, and connect with alumni working in the field.
- Get a graduate degree: Most senior policy roles require an MPH, MPP, MHA, or JD. But many entry-level roles accept a bachelor's degree.
- Stay informed: Read Health Affairs, The Kaiser Family Foundation, and The Commonwealth Fund to understand current health policy debates.

Recommended Textbooks

"Health Economics" by Jay Bhattacharya, Timothy Hyde, and Peter Tu – The most accessible and engaging intro textbook.

"The Economics of Health and Health Care" by Sherman Folland – More comprehensive, used in graduate programs.

"Getting Health Economics Right" by M. Kate Bundorf – Great for decision-makers.

ABOUT THIS RESOURCE

This guide is part of the HealthBridge Library — free resources for every stage of your pre-health journey.

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